

UTT Chapter 01 Assignment

Hello!

Well, I'm finally settled into my dorm room. You wouldn't think that it would take so long to move into a room the size of a closet, but when you're sharing that space with a roommate, you have to be creative.

My roommate, Nathan, is really interesting. After noticing my Bible, he mentioned that he is taking a World Religions class this semester. It sounded like a fascinating class, so I signed up too! My course load this semester is fairly light since it is my first semester and all. In addition to World Religions, I am taking English Composition, Art History, Economics, and Basket Weaving. (Don't laugh!)

Yesterday was the first day of classes. I was really nervous, but I got through it. My World Religions professor is hilarious. He dresses like a hippie and even brought a ukulele to class. It will probably be my most fun course this term. When he began his lecture, he asked each of us to say what religion, if any, we believe in. Many of the students said they believed in Christianity, but a number of them held to Islam, Judaism, and even atheism. Nathan said he was "into spirituality," but I have no idea what he meant by that. I'll have to ask him sometime.

Anyway, back to the lecture. The professor gave a brief rundown of what he called the major "worldviews." Despite my confusion, everyone seemed to understand what that meant, so I didn't ask since I didn't want to look ignorant. He proceeded to say that by the end of the semester, most of the professed Christians would believe something different. Needless to say, I was shocked. After class, I asked the professor why he expected that to happen. We talked for a while before the professor asked me if I thought Christianity was the only way to God. I answered yes, since Christianity is the only religion that acknowledges Jesus as both God and Savior. The professor proposed a different view. He thought that all religions ultimately lead to God. He argued that ultimately religions are just different paths to the same destination. I stammered out a short reply, saying that not all religions believe in Jesus, but it didn't seem to satisfy him. He asked what I knew about other religions, and I admitted that I did not know much. The last thing he said has really had me thinking the last few days. He said, "If you don't know what other religions believe, then how do you know that other religions don't lead to God as well?" I didn't know what to say.

I'd like to be able to defend my faith to him, but the questions he asked made me wonder if I've thought through my beliefs carefully. My professor said he's open to talking about Christianity, but I don't think I know just how to explain it to him. Can you help me figure out what to say? **What is a worldview?** Can you also explain to me **why should we study worldviews?** I mean, I know I should since he pointed out how little I know, but I don't know if I could really say why. He's interested in learning about my beliefs, but **what does it mean to have a Christian worldview?**

Well, it's already past midnight, so I'd better get some sleep. I have a class at 8 a.m. tomorrow and can't skip breakfast if I want to have my brain awake that early!

One last thing ... **do you know why you are a Christian?** I know I am, but after my conversation with the professor, I am not sure I know *why* I am. Just curious.

-Doug

Doug brought up four different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. What is a worldview?

A **worldview** is the pattern of ideas, beliefs, convictions, and habits that help us make sense of God, the world, and our relationship to God and the world. [1.5]

2. Why should we study worldviews?

[Students should give at least one of the responses below.]

As Christians we recognize that we live in a world created and sustained by God. Correctly understanding this world entails having an accurate view of the world, and this means carefully thinking through the ideas we hold. Are our beliefs consistent with Scripture? Are they consistent with each other? And do they adequately make sense of our experiences?

If we want to guard ourselves against false beliefs, it would be prudent to understand those beliefs. Which worldview accepts these ideas? What is the rationale for such ideas? Are these ideas compatible with the beliefs found in Scripture? If not, how can we refute them with truth?

Christ has commanded us to make disciples. If we want to do this effectively, we must learn how to engage the non-Christian beliefs held by our neighbors. If we can defend the Christian worldview and adequately respond to competing worldviews, then we can more adequately help others discover truth. [1.5–1.6]

3. What does it mean to have a Christian worldview?

To have a Christian worldview means that we hold beliefs that agree with the truths found in Scripture, and we compare what we learn and experience in the external world with these truths to evaluate how they line up. We need to be able to distinguish between our Christian views and the views that sneak in from the outside world that don't hold the same priorities as we do. To this end, we need to fill our minds with God's truth so we can speak and act in a way that honors our commitment to Christ. [1.9]

4. Why are you a Christian?

[Answers will vary. Students will likely cite a particular experience, but hopefully they will also give some type of reasoned case for their faith. Whatever their rationale, keep in mind that this might be the first time some of your students have thought through this question.]